



RIGHT TO DELAY

Bihar has the dubious distinction of having seen more than 40 cases of harassment of citizens, including FIRs on trumped up charges all across the state for seeking information under the RTI. We, therefore, were not surprised to see that it took over a year for the information officer to provide information. The RTI Commission in Bihar has a backlog of approximately 10,000 appeals. The RTI Act stipulates there can have 10 information commissioners, but Bihar has only three, which suggests why this many number of cases are pending currently. Incidentally, the three information commissioners, including the chief information commissioner, are retired IAS officers.

MLC DILIP KUMAR JAIWAL WITH ONE OF HIS SET OF POLICE BODYGUARDS

Bihar Home Department's mandarins did neither of the two. They kept the plea pending for months. Though some information trickled in from district authorities earlier, the first letter of information from joint secretary (Home) with details from only 11 districts reached INDIA TODAY after May 29, 2009, seven months after the information was sought. And it was issued after the State RTI Commission issued a warning on April 22, 2009, to slap a fine for not furnishing the information.

There are about 1,357 persons in Bihar who enjoy government protection. In other words, every district has 34 VIPs to look after. The list includes VVIPs, VIPs, district level politicians, bureaucrats, businessmen, professionals and private individuals, including those who pay for the protection.

Worse still, about 2,344 policemen are deployed as bodyguards in Bihar while the number of constables in these districts is 34,514. Thus almost 7 per cent of the total policemen have been deputed as bodyguards in Bihar.

Interestingly, the Bihar Economic Survey 2009 states that the actual working strength of the state police was only 77.7 per cent of the sanctioned posts. Bihar Police Association General Secretary K.K. Jha claims about 10,000 policemen are being used as house guards.

According to the National Crime Records Bureau, Bihar has 60 policemen per lakh of population, the lowest in the country as against the national average of 125 per lakh.

ARARIA-BASED BUSINESSMAN MOOLCHANDA GOLCHHA HAS TWO BODYGUARDS AT HIS DISPOSAL



United Nations' norms seek 222 policemen per one lakh of population. Till September this year, Bihar has witnessed 2,438 murders—which amount to almost 10 killings every day. Indeed, policing is getting increasingly difficult with an inadequate number of policemen.

The other question that emerges from the replies is about the manner in which bodyguards have been deployed. Although there is a security committee in every district to decide the issue, in practice anyone in the good books of a district magistrate or an SP gets free security. These inconsistencies are evident in the

process of allotment of bodyguards. For instance, the Rohtas district authorities granted police bodyguards to 15 non-officials because they received threats.

In his reply, the Rohtas SP has offered no explanation as to why six of these protected men have been made to cough up protection charges while others got it for free. Sometimes these orders were issued citing "public interest". It seems safety has become a matter of perspective. ■